



1973

The first US space station, Skylab, went into orbit. It was to be manned by three successive crews who would perform nearly 300 experiments while on board. Skylab fell back to the Earth in 1979.

1977

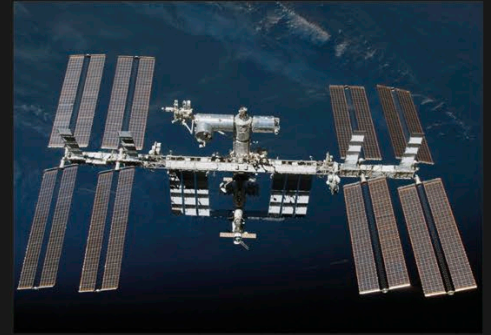
Voyager 2 is launched, closely followed by *Voyager 1*. The spacecraft have studied the solar system's outer planetary systems, and are still operating.

1986

The first section of Mir, the Russian space station, was launched. Mir was the first permanent residence in space and was almost continuously occupied until 2000. Mir burnt up in the Earth's atmosphere, after 15 years in orbit, in 2001.



Lift-off of
Titan III-Centaur
vehicle carrying
Voyager 2



The International Space Station

1998

The first part of the International Space Station (ISS) was launched. Still in operation today, it is powered by large solar panels and orbits the Earth at an altitude of 360 km (225 miles).

2004

Cassini, the first craft to orbit Saturn, sends back the clearest photographs ever of Saturn's ring system. It continues to orbit the planet and its moons today.

2010

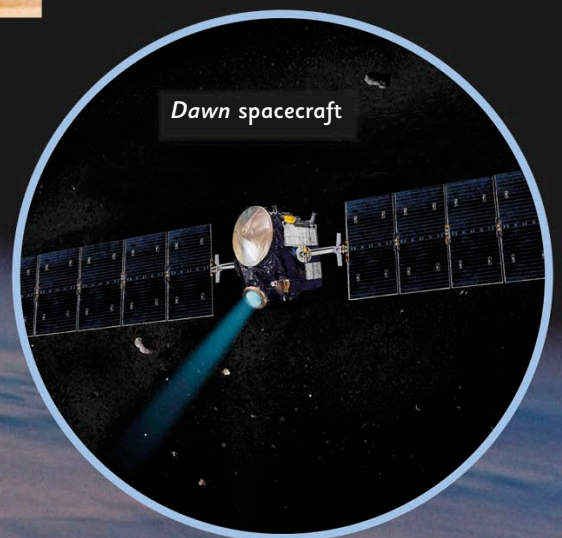
Developed by the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA), the spacecraft *Hayabusa* became the first to return asteroid samples to Earth. It had collected them from the asteroid Itokawa.

2015

NASA's *Dawn* spacecraft became the first to orbit a dwarf planet. It had completed a journey of 4.9 billion km (3.1 billion miles) and seven and a half years, before going into orbit around Ceres.



Mir space station



Dawn spacecraft